

URSULA GÜNTHER
THE NOTICED

Something has shifted in your dreams. You stand in the arena. The crowd is roaring but the sound is wrong — too close, too many voices, all saying your mother’s name in Latin. The axe is in your hands. The floor is wet. You do not look down.

From the imperial box, something watches. It is wearing your mother’s face. It does not look grieved, or satisfied, or triumphant. It looks interested. You are an animal that has done something unexpected, and it would like to see what you do next.

You wake with iron on your tongue. The feeling takes an hour of daylight to clear. Sometimes it does not clear entirely.

THE AXE

Last night the handle of the greataxe was warm before the rest of you was awake. That has not happened before. You did not mention it to anyone.

MECHANICAL EFFECT

Disturbing visions of conquest visit you in sleep. Make a **DC 10 Wisdom saving throw** to remember the dream clearly — on a failure, you wake with only a sense of unease and iron, but no images you can describe. Your GM will tell you when to roll.

JOURNAL PROMPT

What did I dream about, and what does it say about what I am afraid I already want?